Andragogical Inclusion: A Professional Knowledge Exchange

Bridging Lived Experience, Equity, and Academic Rigour in Adult Learning

Community of Practice

Peer Community: Convening as scholarly practitioners sharing expertise.

Critical Andragogy

Critical Synthesis: Interrogating where adult learning theory meets social justice.

Equitable Rigour

Action Horizon: Generating tangible curricular adaptations for next week.

Literal Definition & Etymology

What Does “Andragogy” Literally Mean?



andr-
(Greek: *anēr / andr-*)
“Adult” (literally “man”)

+



-agogy
(Greek: *agōgos*)
“Leading” or “Guiding”

=



Literal Translation
“Leading Adults”

Pedagogy vs. Andragogy

Pedagogy (*paid-* “child” + *agōgos* “leading”) literally means “leading children”—contrasting child instruction with adult guidance.

In Modern Practice (Knowles, 1980)

Defined as “the art and science of helping adults learn”—partnering with self-directed adults across all identities and lived experiences.

Origin: Coined by Alexander Kapp (1833) · Popularised by Knowles, M. S. (1980). *The Modern Practice of Adult Education: From Pedagogy to Andragogy*.

Opening Question

Why is designing and delivering CPD for teaching staff especially difficult?



Gemini Notebook

Knowles' Andragogy Meets Critical Equity (1/2)



Malcolm Knowles
(Classical Theory)

- **Self-Directed**: Adults resist imposed knowledge.
- **Life Experience**: Learners bring a rich reservoir of prior knowledge.
- **Immediate Relevance**: Content must apply to current goals.

Reference: Knowles, M. S. (1980). The Modern Practice of Adult Education: From Pedagogy to Andragogy. · Knowles, M. S., Holton, E. F., & Swanson, R. A.(2020). The Adult Learner (9th ed.).

Gemini Notebook

Knowles' Andragogy Meets Critical Equity (2/2)



The Equity Expansion
(Modern Reality)

- Power Dynamics: Marginalization dictates who feels safe sharing.
- Psychological Safety: Trauma and socioeconomic status condition participation.
- Proactive Design: Inclusion removes barriers before adjustments are requested.

References: Brookfield, S. D. (2005). The Power of Critical Theory for Adult Learning and Teaching. · Edmondson, A. (1999). · CAST (2018). Universal Design for Learning Guidelines.

Gemini Notebook

INTERACTIVE CPD CHECK KNOWLES' ANDRAGOGY × CRITICAL EQUITY

Quick Check: Classical Andragogy or Critical Equity Expansion?

Settings

Malcolm Knowles (Classical Theory)
Self-Directed Autonomy · Prior Life Experience · Immediate Relevance

The Equity Expansion (Modern Reality)
Power Dynamics · Psychological Safety · Proactive Design (UDL)

SCENARIO 1 OF 6

Click card to reveal answer

"Staff replace a generic 2-hour lecture with hands-on case studies solving immediate problems from this week's classes."

Discuss: Does this scenario illustrate **Malcolm Knowles (Classical Theory)** or **The Equity Expansion (Modern Reality)**?

← Previous

1 2 3 4 5 6

Next Scenario →

References: Knowles, M. S. (1980). *The Modern Practice of Adult Education* · Knowles, Holton & Swanson (2020) · Brookfield, S. D. (2005) · Edmondson, A. (1999) · CAST (2018).

Applied Case Studies: Lived Experience

Case Study A



Clinical Audiology

Clinical training with mature healthcare learners

Tension point: Highly demanding learners attempting to monopolise teacher support

Case Study B



HyFlex Health

Allied health learners balancing shifts and childcare

Tension point: Extreme workloads and synchronous distance isolation

Case Study C



Technical Education (Carpentry)

Adult trade & carpentry learners retraining while working

Tension point: Strong practical know-how vs. technical vocabulary and written theory

Listen to the case studies and think about which example best relates to your learners' challenges.

Making a cohort



UCSD

Health Professions and Nursing

Enhancing Healthcare, Changing Lives

Step 1 – Blend in

Talk with at least 8 fellow students in the room

Things you should NOT share about yourself:
What you want to keep private

Step 2 – Find where you belong

Group with 3 other students

When you create the groups be mindful of:

Don't be with someone you work with

Have something **personal** in common with the others

Different work background (e.g. NHS, Private, Not in audiology)

Different work experience (e.g. clinical role, non-clinical role, customer facing, admin)

Step 3 – Set rules and find a voice

Research Through an Inclusion Lens

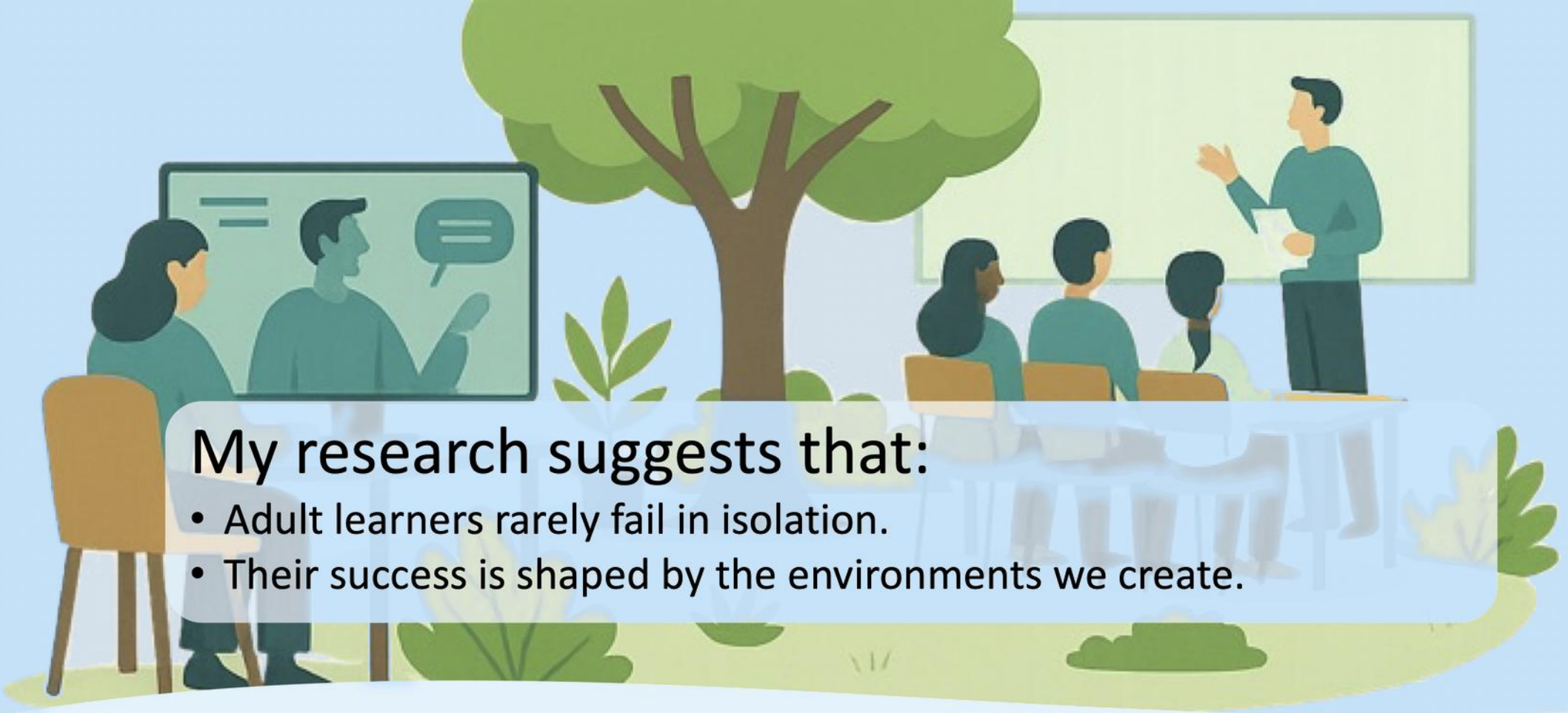
- Level 7 research exploring apprentice experiences
- Focus on experiences within HyFlex learning
- Adult learners balance work, study and personal responsibilities
- Examined barriers and enablers of success



A Question…

- Are you as nosey as me?
- Which group of apprentices did better?
  - Face to Face or Online

- Please stand up if you vote for Face to face
- Stay seated if you vote for Online



My research suggests that:

- Adult learners rarely fail in isolation.
- Their success is shaped by the environments we create.

The result: Adult learners thrive in either setting in Hyflex, due to the ecology we create. Safety, security and compassion foster safe learning, secure knowledge transfer and compassionate academic Assistant Practitioners

Three Lessons for Inclusive Adult Learning



1. BELONGING ENABLES PARTICIPATION



2. CLARITY REDUCES HIDDEN BARRIERS



3. SUPPORT STRENGTHENS RIGOUR

Engagement **is** shaped by the **learning environment.**

Connecting to Andragogical Inclusion



Take-Home Message

Shift the question from: Why is this learner disengaged? to What barriers exist in our learning environment?

Inclusion is removing barriers, not lowering standards.

Semantic Waves (LCT): Tacit-to-Explicit Bridging (1/3)

The Scenario: Sam, 42



- **Context:** Retraining in Technical Education (Carpentry) while working.
- **Strength:** Strong tacit, hands-on practical know-how on the workshop floor.
- **Barrier:** Less confident with technical vocabulary and formal written explanations.

Semantic Waves (LCT): Tacit-to-Explicit Bridging (2/3)

The Research: Legitimation Code Theory (Maton, 2013)

How knowledge moves between **practical mastery** and **abstract theory**



Practical Know-How

(High Semantic Gravity · Low Semantic Density)

Context-dependent, concrete workshop skill and everyday trade vernacular.



Technical Terminology

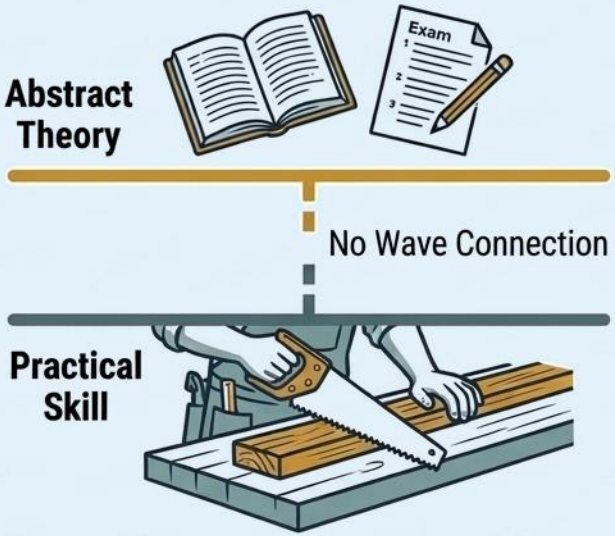
(Low Semantic Gravity · High Semantic Density)

Abstract concepts, condensed industry terminology, and written theory.

Reference: Maton, K. (2013). Making semantic waves: A key to cumulative knowledge-building. *Linguistics and Education*, 24(1), 8–22.

Semantic Waves (LCT): Tacit-to-Explicit Bridging (3/3)

The "Semantic Flatline" Trap (Maton, 2013)



The "Semantic Flatline" Trap: Adult vocational learners often get stuck in a flatline when teaching stays locked on a single plane:

- **Workshop Flatline:** Performing the practical skill brilliantly on the workshop floor without passing written assessments.
- **Textbook Flatline:** Memorising abstract textbook definitions they cannot apply on the workshop floor.

Reference: Maton, K. (2013). Making semantic waves: A key to cumulative knowledge-building. *Linguistics and Education*, 24(1), 8–22.

SCENARIO EXTENSION • SAM, 42 (MATON, 2013)

Semantic Waves: Bridging Practical & Technical

Reverse-Wave Oral-to-Written Strategy: Employ during practical observation before providing vocabulary glossaries or sentence starters.



1. Down-Escalate (Check)

Observe practical task explained in everyday workshop slang.

2. Pivot (Decide)

Swap two colloquial actions for industry terms via voice-note.

3. Up-Escalate (Act)

Probe system changes verbally before requiring written prose.

Diagnostic Purpose: Use before glossaries or sentence starters to separate literacy barriers from conceptual misconceptions.

CHECK → DECIDE → ACT

Case Study Debrief

Thoughts & Reflections

Revisiting Our Earlier Prompt: “Listen to the case studies and think about which example best relates to your learners’ challenges.”



Case Study A · Clinical Audiology
Cohort norms & support boundaries



Case Study B · HyFlex Health
Shifts, care & belonging ecology



Case Study C · Carpentry & LCT
Practical skill vs. written theory

1. **Resonance:** Which case study best mirrors the challenges your own adult learners face—and why?
2. **Takeaway:** Where did inclusive design remove hidden barriers while keeping standards high?

SMALL-GROUP INCLUSION CLINIC • DIAGNOSTIC LENSES

Adult Learner Barriers: 5 Core Lenses

Frame barriers as curriculum design interfaces—not individual learner deficits.



Time Poverty & Role Conflict

- Shift work and unpredictable hours.
- Active parenting and elder care duties.



Neurodivergence & Masking

- High executive load on unstructured tasks.
- Exhaustion from ADHD or autistic masking.



Linguistic & Academic Codes

- Unspoken academic register and jargon.
- Culturally narrow classroom examples.



Digital & Financial Divide

- Mobile-only or shared household devices.
- Low bandwidth and hidden study costs.



Schooling Scars

- Past trauma from deficit formal schooling.
- Fear of exposure masking workplace skill.

The Inclusive Design Clinic (20 Mins)

Designed for ~8 Staff (4 Pairs) · 100% Active Voice · Zero Idle Stalls

Step 1: Pair Diagnosis (5m)



Uncover Hidden Barriers

- **4 Pairs:** Each pair takes one Adult Learner Case Card.
- **Look Deeper:** Map surface classroom friction to the 5 barrier lenses.

Step 2: Design & Pass (8m)



Draft Solutions & Swap

- **Co-Design** (5m): Write 1 Tomorrow Quick Win + 1 UDL Course Fix.
- **Pass Left** (3m): Swap cards clockwise—spot a missed barrier & add 1 upgrade.

Step 3: Table Clinic (7m)



8-Staff Roundtable

- **90s Spotlight:** Share the upgraded card you hold with the group.
- **Rigour Check:** Confirm how standards stay high while barriers drop.

Goal: Co-create 4 peer-tested Barrier-to-Solution blueprints across our 8-person team.

LIVE ACTIVITY BOARD • ASSIGN 1 CARD PER PAIR

4 Adult Learner Case Cards: Diagnose & Solve

Pair 1 · Farah, 34 — Health Retrainer

- **Visible Friction:** Joins online late on mobile, camera off, misses live polls.
- **Hidden Reality:** Rotating NHS night shifts, shared family laptop, noisy home.

Pair 2 · Marcus, 29 — Level 4 Access

- **Visible Friction:** Articulate in class debates, yet misses written draft deadlines.
- **Hidden Reality:** ADHD executive overload triggered by a dense, vague essay brief.

Pair 3 · Elena, 46 — Career Changer

- **Visible Friction:** Over-apologises, seeks constant 1:1 reassurance, avoids peer review.
- **Hidden Reality:** Told at 16 she "wasn't academic"; imposter fear masks 20 yrs' skill.

Pair 4 · Tariq, 38 — Technical & ESOL

- **Visible Friction:** Aces practical workshop tasks; submits thin written evaluations.
- **Hidden Reality:** Translating dense academic idioms alongside work and childcare.

Pair Task: **1.** Name the intersecting barriers → **2.** Propose 1 Quick Win + 1 UDL Fix → **3.** Pass clockwise to upgrade

CLINIC DEBRIEF • BARRIERS ALONGSIDE SOLUTIONS

Adult Learner Barriers & Inclusive Solutions

Adult Learner Barrier	Low-Prep Classroom Fix (Tomorrow)	Proactive UDL Design (Course-Level)
Time Poverty & Care Roles	Upload slides & core tasks 72h ahead	Recorded micro-recaps & flexible check-ins
Neurodivergence & Load	Visual agenda & chunked step checklists	TILT briefs (Purpose, Task, Criteria) + exemplars
Linguistic & Academic Codes	2-min pair rehearsal before room Q&A	Co-created glossaries & Semantic Wave bridging
Digital & Financial Divide	Mobile-friendly PDFs & low-data polls	Offline VLE access & zero hidden software costs
Schooling Scars & Anxiety	Low-stakes anonymous pulse checks	Formative draft stages & multimodal assessment

Inclusion removes environmental friction while preserving—and elevating—academic and professional rigour.

Friction vs. Flow: Inclusive Design Matrix

Friction (Exclusive)	Flow (Inclusive)
Punitive attendance rules	Robust asynchronous scaffolding
Vague, implicit assessment briefs	Transparent in Learning and Teaching (TILT)
Assuming prior academic literacy	Co-created glossaries and term banks
High-bandwidth synchronous demands	Low-bandwidth, flexible access

Gemini Notebook

Plenary: Choose Your Exit Commitment

Andragogy + Equity + Intentional Design = Autonomous Adult Learners

Option A	Option B	Option C
Quick Win	**Critical Tension**	**Peer Pact**
Share a 60-second summary of a barrier you are removing next week.	Pose an unresolved standard vs. flexibility dilemma to the room.	Pair up with a colleague to swap feedback on your redesign.

Gemini Notebook